UNIT 5: WHAT'S NEXT

TOPIC 3: COMMUNITY RESOURCES

Topic OBJECTIVE: The learner will:

- Understand and identify the community agencies that can help support their goals and needs as young adults

Topic OUTCOME: The learner will:

- Know how to locate and contact local community agencies to make self-referrals to help meet their goals and needs

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Large Group Discussion

Objectives:
- Students will understand the meaning of referrals and how they can be valuable tools.
- Students will understand the range of services available to them in their community.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handouts: "Massachusetts DYS: Your Community Resource Guide" and "Gathering Information"

Ask students to identify agencies that may have helped them or their family/friends in the past (United Way, Meals on Wheels, Dress for Success, WIA Youth Programs, etc.). Explain that a referral is sharing information that will help lead individuals to the supporting agencies, schools, training programs, etc. to help meet their goals or needs.

Suggest to students that information about community agencies are everywhere (flyers, newspaper, word-of-mouth, churches, outreach workers, bus stop, doctors' offices, churches, CRC, the web). One of the most up-to-date sources of referrals is the "Massachusetts DYS :Your Community Resource Guide." It is specifically designed to help young people access community agencies, and is divided up by region and service type (Education, Employability, and Social Services — such as parenting, housing, and health). Students can "self-refer" by contacting these agencies.

To help students learn how to navigate the Guide, identify a type of service and ask students to locate the service in a particular region in the Guide. Inform them that the Guide has a Table of Contents along with a list of cities for each of the regions, to make it easier to locate what they need. Of the services listed in the region where your program is located, ask if the students have heard of, used, or know someone who has used any of the agencies listed. If comfortable, have them share their experience being sure to respect confidentiality as needed.

Writing/Reflection/Assessment

Objective: Students will understand and practice making self-referral calls to agencies they think would be helpful in meeting their goals and needs.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handout: "Gathering Information," the "Massachusetts DYS: Your Community Resource Guide," telephone, pens/pencils

Explain to the group that many young people may feel uncomfortable with calling an agency to inquire about its programs and services. Emphasize that these agencies are here to help students, and *want* their "business." Ask the students to find the region in which they live in the "Massachusetts DYS: Your Community Resource Guide," (using the table of contents or the cover/city guide on the back). Ask students to choose an agency or a service that they think would be helpful to them. Using the "Gathering Information" handout, ask students to call their chosen agency, and refer to the list of questions to get further information. Remind students to write down important information during the call.

Technical (Mass CIS)/Research

Objective: Students use online resources to gather information on programs and agencies that will help with the transition to community.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Computers with internet connection, paper, pens/pencils

Ask students to log on to the Massachusetts State website **(www.mass.gov)** and click on the **"For Residents"** link followed by the **"Young Adults"** link. Explain to students that this section of the site has an incredible amount of information on many aspects of young people living independently and establishing themselves in Massachusetts — housing assistance, training programs, how to get health care, register to vote, job search, driver's license, recreation, etc. Suggest to students that they look up at least two or three resources they are interested in learning more about and have them copy down the agencies contact information, along with the web address.

Gathering Information

Often you'll need to search and learn what is available in your community.
If you have questions, ***call to get the answers.***
Never worry that you may "bother" someone. These organizations are there to serve you and will welcome your call.
If they can't help you, they'll probably be able to direct you to someone who can.

BE SURE TO ASK FOR CORRECT SPELLING OF NAMES AND ADDRESSES

Here are some questions you might want to ask:

What is the name of the organization?

What is your address?

What is your telephone number?

Who am I talking with, please?

Who else should I talk with at the organization?

What services are offered?

Who can use the services?

How much do the services cost?

Are there special ways to qualify for the services?

Do you know of other organizations that offer services that would help me?

How long can I use the services for?

Do you have e-mail and/or a website?

Notes:

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